It was the same old problem, he explained. I was facing a longish school holiday, over Easter, and something needed to be done with me. So, Africa. Botswana, to be precise. A safari.

Safari! With you, Pa?

No. Alas, he wouldn't be going along this time. But Willy would.

Oh, good.

And someone very special, he added, acting as our African guide.

Who, Pa?

Marko.

Marko? I barely knew the man, though I'd heard good things. He was Willy's minder, and Willy seemed to like him very much. Everyone did, for that matter. Of all Pa's people there was consensus that Marko was the best. The roughest, the toughest, the most dashing.

Longtime Welsh Guard. Raconteur. Man's man, through and through.

I was so excited about the prospect of this Marko-led safari, I don't know how I got through the following weeks of school. I don't actually *recall* getting through them, in fact. Memory winks out completely, right after Pa delivered the news, then snaps back into focus as I'm boarding a British Airways jet with Marko and Willy and Tiggy—one of our nannies. Our favorite nanny, to be accurate, though Tiggy couldn't stand being called that. She'd bite the head off anyone who tried. *I'm not the nanny, I'm your friend!*

Mummy, sadly, didn't see it that way. Mummy saw Tiggy not as a nanny but as a rival. It's common knowledge that Mummy suspected Tiggy was being groomed as her future replacement. (Did Mummy see Tiggy as her Spare?) Now this same woman whom Mummy feared as her possible replacement was her actual replacement—how dreadful for Mummy. Every hug or head pat from Tiggy, therefore, must've unleashed some twinge of guilt, some throb of disloyalty, and yet I don't remember that. I remember only heart-racing joy to have Tiggy next to me, telling me to buckle my seatbelt.

We flew direct to Johannesburg, then by prop plane to Maun, the largest city in northern Botswana. There we met up with a large group of safari guides, who steered us into a convoy of open-topped Land Cruisers. We drove off, straight into pure wilderness, towards the vast Okavango Delta, which I soon discovered was possibly the most exquisite place in the world.

The Okavango is often called a river, but that's like calling Windsor Castle a house. A vast inland delta, smack in the middle of the Kalahari Desert, one of the